

Maria Silva

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LLB and LLM graduate with practical experience supporting complex disputes, case preparation and client-facing legal advisory work at BCLP, Q-Legal and Citizens Advice. Experienced in managing case files, tracking deadlines, preparing hearing bundles, drafting procedural and correspondence documents, and communicating with clients on sensitive matters across a range of legal areas including disputes, data privacy, housing, employment and welfare. Strong legal research and written communication skills, with a developed interest in regulatory and public-interest legal work.

EDUCATION

Comparative and International Dispute Resolution LLM — Merit Sept 2024 – Oct 2025

Queen Mary University of London

- Modules in international arbitration, dispute resolution procedure, legal research and evidence analysis
- Dissertation: data protection and the development of GDPR across jurisdictions — Distinction, 75%

Law LLB — 2:1 Sept 2020 – June 2024

University College London

- Modules included Alternative Dispute Resolution, Advanced Contract Law, Commercial Law and Company Law

International Foundation Programme in Law and International Relations Sept 2019 – June 2020

King's College London

- Awarded the Leaders of Tomorrow prize (top 20 of a 200-student cohort; partial funding toward undergraduate degree)

EXPERIENCE

Citizens Advice East Berkshire · Maidenhead July 2026 – Present

Legal Adviser

- Manages a varied caseload spanning welfare benefits, employment, housing, family, debt and consumer matters; takes detailed factual statements, establishes chronologies and identifies relevant legal and evidential issues
- Assesses eligibility for Universal Credit, Housing Benefit and related support against statutory criteria; identifies evidential gaps and researches complex points of law
- Manages matters from instruction through to submission: drafts correspondence, prepares applications and document schedules, maintains confidential case records and meets deadlines
- Advises clients on procedural requirements and available options; translates complex rules into clear, practical guidance for vulnerable individuals

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London Feb 2024 – Aug 2024

Legal Placement Student — International Arbitration

- Supported a complex investment arbitration: reviewed and organised evidence for procedural submissions and the Claimant's memorial; amended sections of the memorial and drafted procedural orders and procedural histories
- Became the only junior supporting the team shortly before a significant deadline: coordinated documents, tracked outstanding actions and liaised with the client and an external translator to ensure on-time submission
- Maintained structured electronic case files and monitored procedural deadlines throughout the matter
- Received feedback from a partner and associate that performance was comparable to a newly qualified solicitor

Bryan Cave Leighton Paisner LLP (BCLP) · London

Legal Placement Student — Real Estate Disputes

Aug 2023 – Feb 2024

- Supported hearing preparation across several matters: reviewed documents, prepared electronic bundles and assisted with skeleton arguments and court materials
- Conducted legal and factual research on rights of light, easements, leasehold issues and landlord and tenant disputes
- Prepared client notes; maintained matter records via iManage; assisted with court filings, hearing arrangements, matter opening and closure, deadline tracking and cost comparisons
- Managed large volumes of confidential documents across competing deadlines

Q-Legal · London

Oct 2024 – Jan 2025

Legal Adviser

- Managed a data privacy matter from client instruction through to a formal written advice letter, under a qualified solicitor's supervision
- Researched UK GDPR and Data Protection Act 2018 obligations for a data-driven start-up, including children's personal data and adtech; identified compliance risks and recommended practical mitigations
- Translated complex statutory requirements into clear, commercially focused advice; coordinated with the client and supervising solicitor to meet the submission deadline

Adobe · London

June 2022 – Aug 2022

Legal Intern

- Reviewed and amended software licensing agreements; identified contractual risks and assessed alignment with internal legal and compliance requirements
- Reviewed confidentiality and data-processing provisions; researched UK GDPR, EU GDPR and cross-border personal data transfer requirements
- Liaised with sales, legal and international business teams to resolve contractual queries and reconcile commercial objectives with legal risk
- Prepared and delivered an internal presentation on breach-of-contract risks and mitigation measures

SKILLS

Languages: Portuguese (native), English (fluent), Spanish (basic)

Technical skills: Legal and commercial research; documentary analysis; concise report and correspondence drafting; Microsoft Word, Excel and PowerPoint; iManage; legal research databases; electronic court filing portals; document review; electronic bundling; case management and time-recording systems

Case and evidence management: Evidence review, hearing bundle preparation, procedural histories, case-file organisation, deadline tracking across multiple concurrent matters